

Chapter 1: The Quiet Math

The sun came up sometime after we cleared the cloud line. The first flights out of Savannah leave at five forty-five, and I had taken so many of them by then that I had a discipline about it: never leave the night before a meeting, because every airline delay stacks on every other delay until the crews time out and the last flights of the day go nowhere; first flights almost always leave on time, and even weather around them costs you maybe twenty minutes. I was heading north — Philadelphia or Boston, two deals that had been quiet for months and had suddenly come back to life over the same weekend. My garment bag was in the overhead. My grip was under the seat in front of me. The grip is a leather bag from the time of steam locomotives. It had been with me through most of the fifty-eight countries I have traveled to as of this writing. It had a laptop and a few essentials and could carry me for two weeks of meetings before laundry was a crisis.

I am a daydreamer. I have always been a daydreamer. Watching the sun come up out of a plane window is one of the moments I find myself most often inside something I cannot quite see the edges of — half here, half pulled toward something that might have happened decades ago, or might be happening on the ground a few hundred miles below me, or might be something I do not yet have a name for.

That morning, the thing I was thinking about was my son.

He was in a NICU in Savannah. He had been born in August when his due date had been October, and he was in there for what would turn out to be the better part of two months. The nurses had told me, nervously, that it isn't good for babies to go without being held by a human — they tried, they always tried, but there were so many babies and so few nurses, and could I come and lie back in the chair beside his bed and let them set him on my chest, and let him feel that connection. There was nothing more important to me than giving him that. He was forming the first connection he would ever form with another person. I tried to be there every day, and I almost always was. I matched my visits to his NICU schedule so I could share different parts of the day with him and not arrive while he was scheduled to be asleep — holding his hands and feet, changing him, feeding him at feeding time. But getting a chair and lying back with him on my chest needed the nurses to be slow enough to set up the wires and hoses safely, and that was only two or three days out of seven.

I was thinking about him on that plane, and as planes will do, the thinking slipped backward.

I thought of the mornings my father drove me into the Appalachians when I was a boy. He would not talk much. He would sit beside me in the dark, the headlights on the empty road, and we would go deep

into the mountains before the sun came up. He was teaching me to hunt. We rarely brought anything home. He would point out the birds. He would name the trees. He would say, every once in a while, almost wistfully — *the best part of any trip is the journey*. When I was young I thought he was talking about the scenery. Later I thought he was offering some kind of Stoic advice about not being too fixed on the goal. It was not until we had stopped hunting that I understood. He was talking about getting to spend time with me.

I did not think any of this because I had figured anything out. I thought it because I was on a plane going north and my son was on a different schedule than the rest of the world, and the same nurses who could not give him enough human contact had told me, almost apologetically, that it was good when I came.

The man my son would never meet was my grandfather. They called him Pooh, which my father told me about decades after the fact. The story I knew about him first was the air compressor.

My grandfather had built a workshop behind his house. He spent his hours outside of work there. He worked his entire career at NASA Langley, in Hampton, Virginia — first when the agency was NACA, then after it became NASA in 1958 — and retired from there shortly before he passed. He was a model maker in the wind tunnels — a title he was proud of — and an inventor with his name in the patent record. He had a way of solving things, my father said, things that other people would just give up on, walk past, or simply avoid because they were too difficult.

My father visited him once and noticed the air compressor was moved from its normal location. In a workshop where each tool lived in its assigned place, that struck him. He asked to borrow a drill bit, his eye on the compressor. My grandfather said the bits were worn out — they weren't ready to use. Almost as an afterthought, he mentioned that the compressor's engine had given out. A week or two later my father stopped in again and the compressor was running. He asked what had happened. My grandfather shrugged without turning his head and said he had machined new pistons and new rings, then rebuilt it. He nodded toward the drill bits. *Those are good to go now*, he said. He had sharpened them. He didn't think anything of it.

Years after this, my sister had a son. He was learning everyone's names. He pointed at her and said *momma*. He pointed at me and said *Uncle Chris*. He pointed at my father and tried to say *Pappou*, the Greek word for grandfather. What came out of his mouth was *Pou*. My father got a particular kind of smile on his face, and something in his eye that I did not at the time understand, and he nodded. *Pou it is*, he said. He did not explain anything to anyone in the room. I did not know, then, that his own father had been called Pooh. I would not know that for another six or eight years.

I learned to work from my father.

He had a way of giving advice that was almost not advice. When I was a boy he would say — even if I decided to dig ditches for a living — that at the end of the day I should be able to look at my work and know in my heart that no one had ever done better. He said pride in your own work makes the hard days a little easier, and that knowing you did a good job is often enough, even when no one else will ever see it.

He had a way of asking me, before he came to look at something I had been doing, whether I would be proud of what he was about to see. He did not force me to answer. He did not need to. The question

did the work.

I remember one afternoon. He had given my sister and me something to do — clean the living room, or the backyard. We were small. We hurried through it. We swept the dust under a corner of the rug. We pushed the sticks from the yard under the old shed. We came back and said we were done and asked if we could go play. He started to rise from his chair, and then he paused. *Before I get up*, he said, *when I go check the work, will you be proud of what I am about to see?* My sister and I looked at each other. *Wait*, we said. *Wait. Don't get up yet. Let us just do a quick walk through.* We ran to the rug with a broom and a dustpan and carried the dust to the trash. We crawled under the shed and pulled out the sticks and broke them down. We edged the lawn. We swept the sidewalks. By the time we walked back to him we were standing taller. We were ready for him to look.

He was a naval architect, a civil servant employed by the Navy who held a high clearance and traveled on a political passport. He was tight-lipped about what he actually did day to day. He sat in rooms with captains and admirals. When I was old enough to hear some of the vague stories, what I learned from them was never about subject matter. It was about how to hold a room of large personalities. He never raised his voice. He did not even speak at a normal volume. He spoke a hair below it, and only when he had something worth saying. The reaction in a room of loud, talking adults when somebody with something worth listening to starts speaking just below the room's volume is a thing I have used my entire career. You don't have to exercise power over the others in the room. They quiet themselves down.

My grandfather had passed it to him quietly. He passed it to me the same way.

I had already been in sales for years. But I started my IT career at the National Institutes of Health, twenty-two years old, on a contract that was supposed to last three months. The Human Genome Project would complete during my time there. I cannot lay claim to completing that work — it belonged to researchers I still consider some of the greatest minds in the world. My job was downstream of theirs. I built the websites that took their research, arranged the peer review, and translated the insights so they were useful to different audiences.

That sounds simple. It was deceptively difficult. The same paper on a marker for a rare genetic issue had to be technically rigorous enough for the researchers in the field to take seriously, and accessible enough that a child living with that genetic issue could understand, on the same page, what the scientists had found and what it might mean. The fifteen audiences spanned from other researchers who would take the new findings and run with them, to the children with those diseases themselves. We were not telling sick children we had a cure — we were explaining to them that people were trying to help, and that the work might one day mean a different future for children like them. A child's smile when she understood that meant something. Those smiles are why I stopped sleeping.

Which I didn't, much. The first contract was supposed to be three months, but the project I had been brought in to look at had been running for two years already. It had been planned for a team of more than forty people, one year, one million dollars. By the time I arrived it was at a million and a half and a year past due, and the team's plan was to ask for another year, another million dollars, and more people. I looked at it, and realized that even as people explained enough for me to understand the project, they were spending most of their time explaining why so much additional work had been added. So I cut everything that was not aligned with the original scope. Three months later I had a working proof of

concept. The contract got renewed. They had another project they wanted me to look at, one another team had given up on. Then another. The renewals kept coming.

I was good at this, and I want to be honest about the shape of it. The work was meaningful, and the pride in it was part of the work itself. There is a real satisfaction that comes from looking at a finished piece and knowing it was good even when no one else will ever see what your contribution was. I learned that satisfaction at the NIH. The lesson was already in me — my father had put it there long before — but the NIH was where I first learned it could carry an adult through weeks of grinding a problem until a solution would form. I carried that lesson the rest of my career.

That pattern I learned at the NIH would, twenty years later, cost me my marriage and the early years with my son.

I billed over a hundred and twenty hours a week for stretches, sometimes for months at a time. There were three weeks back to back, right before a project deadline, where I billed close to a hundred and thirty-eight hours every seven days. I delivered the project early. There was a stack of paper paychecks on my desk that I had not opened. My hair grew long because I did not have time for haircuts; I started shaving my own head in the bathroom, on mute during conference calls. On the days I remembered to eat, I ordered through a drive-through window on mute during conference calls. I have a memory of waking up one morning at my desk, the laptop still open in front of me, and realizing I had fallen asleep mid-sentence typing an email — I do not remember to whom; I do not remember about what; the thing I remember is cussing at myself for not having clicked send before sleep took me, because someone had needed it before they woke up so they could keep the work going.

Sleep took me. By then I had stopped choosing it.

The NIH contracts ended naturally and on good terms. The man who had been bringing me into project after project was on a golf course one weekend, talking with friends from the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank. Both had projects their teams were stuck on. He called me Monday morning. That was how I left the NIH. That was how the next decade began.

I moved to the Washington D.C./Maryland/Virginia area. The DMV, if you know it. Like most new people in D.C., I had to commute to and from my office every day. I was new to city life but I knew the math everyone knew: living outside the city was cheaper. And sure enough, I found a place with more square footage and an extra bedroom for three hundred dollars less per month than anything I could find near my office. I drove the route once before signing — late at night, a forty-eight-minute trip end to end. I thought I knew what I was getting into. The first day I commuted during work hours took me two and a half hours each way: drive to the subway, park, ride the train into the city. Plus forty dollars for parking — though I learned quickly that parking in alleys and absorbing the occasional ticket came out cheaper. I got home at eight, completely drained of any optimism I'd had about the lease. I worked five days a week, six when we were busy. Five days a week, fifty-two weeks a year, five hours a day commuting. The math without looking at a calculator: thirteen hundred hours. Time enough to learn a language. Time enough to play an instrument. Time enough to fall in love. ...Time enough to fall out of love. I would never make that mistake again. It would be years before I had a name for what the lease had actually cost me.

Years later, as a CEO, I drove up to a cable TV station on the East Coast at night. They had reached me six days before they would have run dead air on every commercial break for the rest of the week. To

put that in perspective, that would mean refunding all revenue from those commercials and likely losing those companies as clients. The system that hosted commercials was working perfectly; the system that uploaded new ones into it was offline, and nobody in the building knew where the server was. I asked everyone the same question I have always asked when something has stopped working that used to work: *has anything changed in the last week?* A new guy pointed at a dusty server in a corner. *A few days ago there was a storm. The red light on that one stopped blinking.* He didn't know what the server did. Nobody there did. They were not negligent. They were a group of competent people who had inherited systems other people had installed, and they followed the documented startup and shutdown sequences and, between them, did the work they had been trained to do. To ask them where a wire went, or where the servers were, was a different kind of question.

The server was a decade-old machine from a famous broadcasting company. The company called around and found a warehouse with extra parts that had never been used. They put me on the phone with a warehouse worker in Chicago who said he would get on a plane if I bought him a roundtrip ticket and put cash in his hand. Across the warehouse search, the meetings to release the funds, and the part's flight in, I slept in stretches on the production suite floor under the mixing board — three and a half hours, then half an hour at a time. We were back up in three days. The station thanked us and asked about further work; when I gave them numbers for a retainer, they declined.

I think of the NIH-era job and the cable-TV-station rescue as the same skill — the one my grandfather used when he sharpened the drill bits. It was the willingness to refocus on what the actual problem was, to ask a question nobody else was asking, to work at the seams the documentation had not covered. I had no special knowledge in either case. I just was not afraid. The people who were afraid were not failing. They were doing exactly what their roles told them to do. The institutional architecture did not include — could not include — the question I happened to walk in willing to ask.

I did not understand any of this as a framework when I was doing it. I understood it as work. The framing came later, much later, after I had absorbed enough of the cost into my own body that I had time to look at what had been happening.

I was thirty-eight years old and on a plane heading north because the company I worked for had said paternity leave was over and FMLA leave had run out, and it was time to do what I was good at again. It was time to do my job. So I did.

My employer was not cruel. My colleagues were not indifferent. I had built a career on showing people how the value of what I sold aligned with what they needed and how it would solve the issue they had walked into the meeting with. That ability was valuable to the company. The company did what its institutional protocols said to do — paternity leave ends; FMLA leave exhausts; back to work. The system did exactly what the system was designed to do. There was no villain in it.

A free-market economist would say I made voluntary trade-offs. I did. I had options a coal miner in McDowell County does not have. I had elite technical skills, multiple employers, geographic mobility, and significant compensation. And I still ended up, that morning, on a plane heading north, trying not to think about a NICU in Savannah where my son was waiting to be held by a human, while my parents — eight hundred miles north of him and a continent away from me in any way that mattered — were visibly moving slower these days.

I have done the quiet math we all eventually do. If I disappear for another few years, surfacing only for weddings and Thanksgivings, the odds are growing that the next flight home will be for something I cannot bear to name. These are the years I have with them. I intend to be present with them, to laugh with them, and to be here for them when there is no laughter left.

I did not understand, at thirty-eight, on that plane, that this was the math the framework would later let me put a number on. I just knew the math was there.

The mornings I held my son went mostly the same way. I sat in a reclining chair beside his bed in the colored light of the NICU. Nurses moved past us in every direction, handling beeps and alarms, working through the bath schedule, the feeding schedule, the rotations. It was not quiet. He weighed almost nothing. I held him with one hand on his back and the other under his lower body, in case he tried to roll, and he never tried to roll. He settled in immediately and did not move. I practiced single-pointed meditation. I counted my breaths, seven on the inhale or eleven on the inhale, whichever I had landed on for that session, the exhale matched to whichever number it was. There was no other place I was. There was no other thing I was doing.

Those hours were the most present I have ever been in my life.

I had to leave for the airport when paternity leave ended. The deals had to close. The mortgage had to be paid. The house in Savannah had to keep its lights on. The marriage did not survive the trauma of all of it. The house is not the thing I miss.

My son is somewhere in the world now. I don't know where. I wish I knew. We have no contact.

I did not have the words to describe what was happening then. I do now. The framework in this book is how I learned to account for what happened. It does not undo it. It is not a redemption mechanism. It is an honest accounting.

The work of naming what hides behind a mask — Dunbar's mask, Du Bois's veil — is older than this book. Black American writing has carried that work for over a century. The framework extends the move into the pricing of commons. The pricing is new; the move is old.

It is a way of seeing the architecture clearly enough to name what is being absorbed by which people, and a way of asking — at last, after the fact — whether the people absorbing the cost were the people who agreed to absorb it. The chapters that follow walk through it carefully, at different scales, against different cases. None of it brings my son back. None of it is meant to. The framework is for the ones who come after. It is for the costs that are still ahead of us, that we still have a chance to see.

The plane was past the cloud line. The sun was up. The day was beginning. I had work to do.

— End of Chapter 1 —